had gone from being city of Mughal memories to a grand Imperial dream and then to a city of refugees.

If the migration happened in one big rush in Punjab, it was spread over many years in Bengal. A series of anti-Hindu riots in East Pakistan in 1949–50 forced a second spike in refugee movements, with 1.7 million coming to West Bengal in 1950 alone.[3] A steady trickle continued for over a decade. Indeed, many members of my mother's family made the shift only in the early sixties. The luckier refugees stayed with relatives and friends but, as in Delhi, many squatted wherever they could—in railways stations, unoccupied homes, vacant land and even barracks. There have been accusations, arguably true, that the national government in Delhi did far less to rehabilitate the Bengali refugees than their Punjabi counterparts. Still, unlike in West Pakistan, a sizeable Hindu population continued to live in East Pakistan. They would face a second crisis two decades later.

Despite all their troubles, the Punjabis and Bengalis at least had provinces, namely West Bengal and East Punjab, that they could call their own. The sorriest communities, therefore, were those that could no longer lay claim to any territory. For instance, the Sindhi Hindus found that their entire province was part of Pakistan. Many of them headed for Bombay, where they were accommodated in five refugee camps. A concentration of Sindhis remains in Ulhasnagar, an industrial suburb of Mumbai. Over the years, however, they have migrated all over the world and today run a network of international businesses. Hong Kong, for instance, has a significant number of successful Sindhi business families. I have attended Sindhi community gatherings in the former British colony. It is touching to see how old customs have been lovingly kept alive by a generation that has had no contact with the original homeland.

ABSORBING THE PRINCELY STATES

The partition of British India was not the only territorial problem faced by the country at independence. Over a third of the country was ruled by princes, over 500 of them. Some of them ruled kingdoms that were as big as